and heating needs. This was the second largest decline in the world after China, which saw a tremendous reduction to the tune of 220 million households.

About 3.8 billion people (49 per cent of the global population) are still exposed to indoor pollution on account of using solid fuels. The number is the highest in Sub-Saharan Africa where several countries have almost every household using solid fuels. India's good performance is partly explained by the expansion of schemes like the Ujjwala Yojana, which has led to the provision of an LPG connection to over 80 million families, most of whom were earlier using solid fuels, including kerosene. There has been a remarkable decline in the use of kerosene in the country.

That said, India needs to urgently attend to the matter of the worst quality of air in the world, which continues to deteriorate. In fact, the situation in several pockets is even more dire than what the national average conveys.

Water Quality is Also a Matter of Serious Concern

Quality of water is extremely important for both human and aquatic life. India monitors about 3500 locations for water quality. This network of monitoring stations covers over 1800 locations on rivers, about 475 lakes/ponds/tanks, about fifty canals, about fifty creeks and seawater locations, fifty drains, fifty sewage treatment plants, ten water treatment plants and about 1000 wells.

Biological, chemical and physical aspects of water impact its quality in terms of fitness for bathing, drinking and supporting aquatic life. Water quality aspects to be assessed include temperature (impacts life and reproduction of aquatic organisms); turbidity (impacts light penetration that affects productivity of plants in waterbodies); bacteria (pathogens coming from human and animal waste are a health risk); dissolved oxygen (concentration of dissolved oxygen necessary for aquatic life); pH (balance